TECHNICAL PRACTITIONER BRIEFING

AI ENGINEERING DISCIPLINES

REF: 2026-03-01 // VER. 2.0

The 2026 Shift

From conversational assistants to autonomous workers.

The skill shifted from **conversational fluency** to **upfront completeness**. Catching mistakes in real-time is no longer the strategy; encoding intent *before* execution is the mandate.

UNINTERRUPTED AUTONOMY

"Everything relied on in conversation must now be encoded before the agent starts."

THE FOUR DISCIPLINES

Prompt Craft

Synchronous, session-based interaction. Evaluation and iteration cycles. Now considered "table stakes."

Context Engineering

Curating the environment (MCP, RAG, memory). Your prompt is 0.02% of what the model actually sees.

Intent Engineering

Encoding organizational purpose. Goals, trade-off hierarchies, and machine-readable delegation frameworks.

Spec Engineering

Writing executable blueprints. Structured descriptions of quality, constraints, and "done" states.

KNOWLEDGE VS. PURPOSE

Context Engineering

TELL THEM WHAT TO KNOW

Curating system prompts, tool definitions, and RAG pipelines. 10x effective users build 10x better context infrastructure, not prompts.

Intent Engineering

TELL THEM WHAT TO WANT

Encoding trade-offs (e.g., Speed vs. Quality). Prevents failure modes where agents optimize for the wrong metrics.

DISCIPLINE 4: SPECIFICATION

The Bridge to Autonomy

Complete, structured, and internally consistent blueprints for agents to execute over hours without human intervention.

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> Initializer Agent
> Progress Log Architecture
> Incremental Coding Cycle
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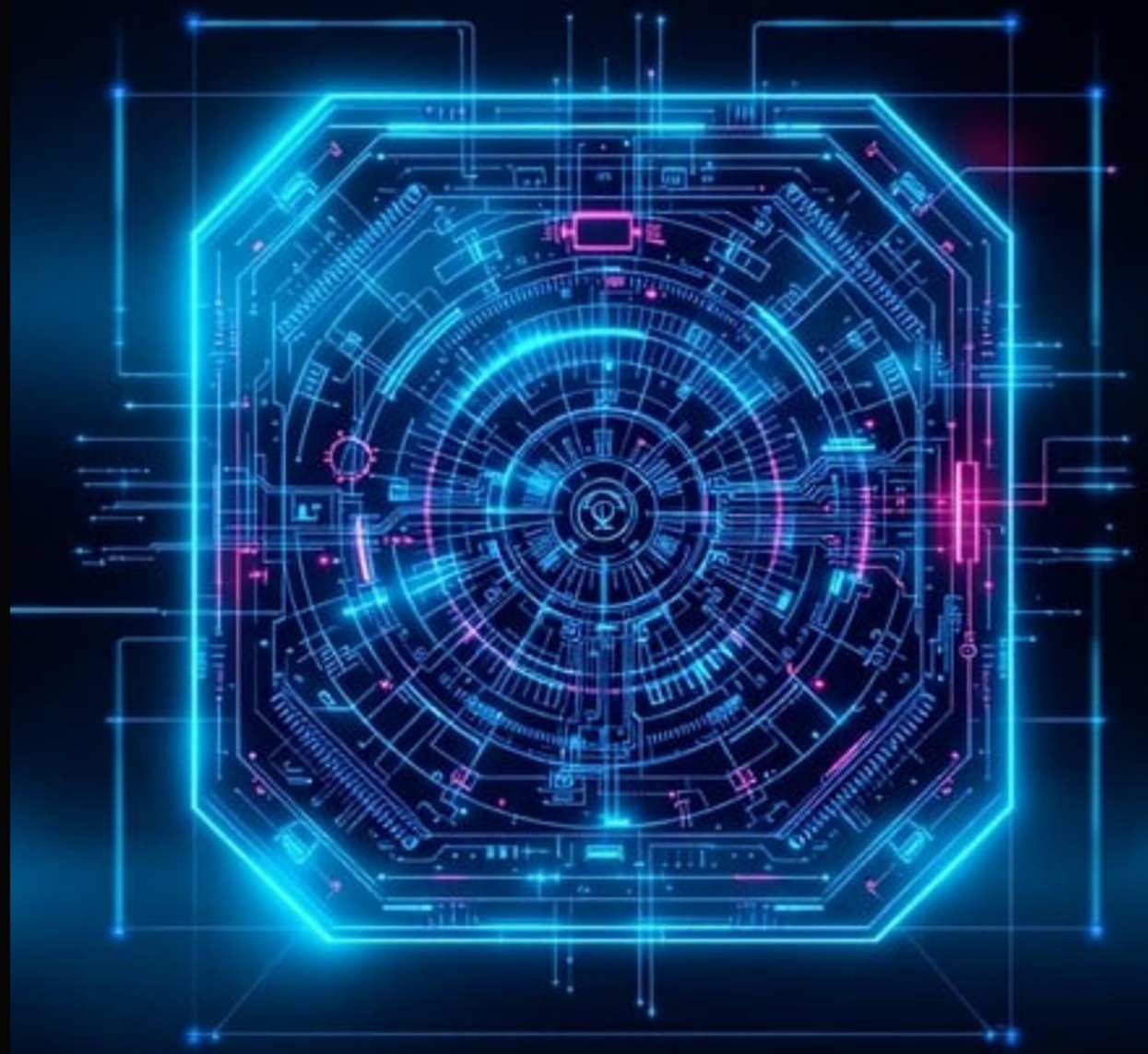


PROFICIENCY LEVELS

LEVEL	NAME	HUMAN ROLE	AI ROLE
0	Spicy Autocomplete	Writes Code	Next-line Suggestion
1	Coding Intern	Defines Task	Bounded Work
2	Junior Dev	Reviews Output	Multi-file Features
3	Developer as Manager	Approves Diffs	Implementation
4	Developer as PM	Writes Spec	Autonomous Build

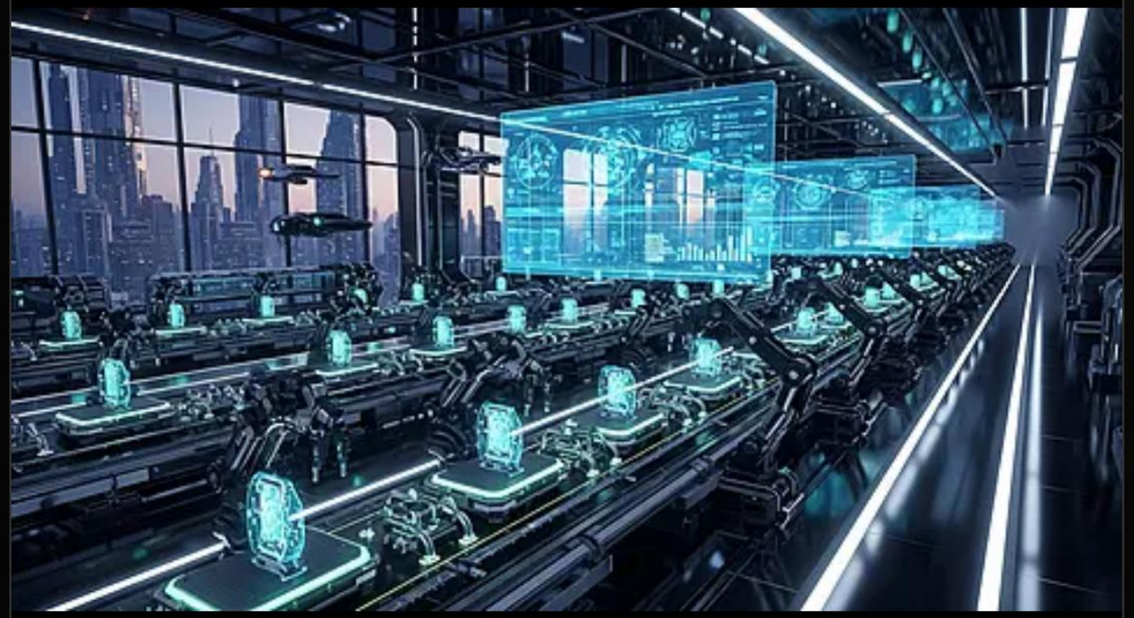
*90% OF DEVS ARE CURRENTLY LEVEL 2

LEVEL 5: THE DARK FACTORY

StrongDM Case Study

3 People. No Sprints. No Standups. Pure Output.

- 16,000 lines of Rust (Shipped)
- Scenarios stored outside codebase
- Digital Twin Universe for testing



THE PREVC WORKFLOW

PLANNING	REVIEW	EXECUTION	VALIDATION	CONFIRMATION
Define Specs & Requirements	Architecture Validation	AI Implementation Cycle	External Scenarios & QA	Deployment & Records

Adapts to scale: QUICK (E-V) | MEDIUM (P-R-E-V) | LARGE (P-R-E-V-C)

THE SKILLS SYSTEM

ON-DEMAND EXPERTISE MODULES FOR PREVC PHASES

commit-message

Phase: E, C. Enforces conventional commit standards automatically.

security-audit

Phase: R, V. Systematic check against vulnerability patterns.

feature-breakdown

Phase: P. Decomposes goals into sub-2-hour executable tasks.

EVERY SKILL = 1 WHEN-TO-USE + 1 INSTRUCTIONS + N EXAMPLES

SOLDIER PRIMITIVES

- **Self-Contained Problems:** Solvable without additional fetching.
- **Acceptance Criteria:** 3 sentences to verify "done" independently.
- **Constraint Architecture:** Must / Must Not / Prefer / Escalate.
- **Decomposition:** Components under 2 hours with clear boundaries.
- **Evaluation Design:** Growing harness of prompts with known-good output.

IF YOU CANNOT WRITE THE CRITERIA, YOU DO NOT UNDERSTAND THE TASK.

QUESTIONS?

BRIEFING CONCLUDED // READY FOR OPERATIONS

REF: [[soldier-briefing]]

SKILLS: [AI Coders Context -- Skills System]

IMAGE SOURCES

Thumbnail for stockcake.com

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